

PUBLIC SPACE AND EVERYDAY SOCIABILITY

Undergraduate Dissertation - Department of Sociology, Example University

ABSTRACT

This dissertation examines how the design and management of public spaces shapes casual encounters between strangers. Drawing on three months of observation in two city squares, it argues that "loose" spaces - movable seating, mixed uses, few rules - generate more spontaneous sociability than tightly programmed ones.

1. INTRODUCTION

Cities are made of more than buildings; they are made of the small, repeated encounters that happen in shared space. This study asks what makes some public spaces feel sociable and others empty.

2. LITERATURE

Building on classic work on public life and "third places", the review sets out three mechanisms: comfort, triangulation, and lingering.

3. METHODS

Systematic observation, behavioural mapping, and twelve short intercept interviews.

4. FINDINGS

Loose spaces hosted 2-3x more lingering and far more cross-group talk.

5. CONCLUSION

Small design choices - where a bench faces, whether chairs move - shape sociability.

(Sample document generated for demonstration. No real data.)